CANCER

FATAL DETECTION DELAYS

Cancers that are otherwise treatable are advancing to late stages due to late diagnoses, while the absence of reliable data continues to undermine policies for terminal cancer care

By SONALI ACHARJEE



TARGETED APPROACH
A radiation machine at Apollo Hospitals, New Delhi

ARUN KUMAR

By the time 46-year-old schoolteacher Ritu Sharma (*name changed*) first walked into a Delhi oncology OPD, she had already been living with cancer for months—without knowing it. The backache began as a dull tug between her shoulder blades, then grew into a burning sensation that woke her at 3 am every night. She blamed posture, age, stress. When she first had a cough, she was given antibiotics, and then vitamins. By the time she reached a tertiary hospital, scans revealed her cancer had metastasised, meaning it had spread to other organs, with lesions in her spine and spots in her lungs.

Sharma's story is painfully familiar. India's cancer burden is rising fast. The country ranks second in Asia and third globally in cancer cases. An analysis of 43 population-based cancer registries published in *JAMA Network Open* in 2025 estimated India's lifetime cancer risk at 11 per cent—meaning nearly one in nine people may develop cancer. According to Global Cancer Observatory (GLOBOCAN) predictions, cancer cases in India would increase to 2.08 million by 2040, accounting for a rise of 57.5 per cent from 2020.

More alarming than the rise in incidence, however, is how cancers are being detected only after they have spread. A 2025 task force report from the National Academy of Medical Sciences estimates that over 60 per cent of breast cancer cases in India present at Stage III or IV—well beyond the window for early intervention. The pattern is similar across cancers: nearly 80 per cent of oral cancer patients reach hospitals at an advanced stage; 45–50 per cent of lung cancer patients are already metastatic at first presentation; over 55 per cent of cervical cancer patients seek treatment at Stage III or higher; and about half of stomach cancers are diagnosed at Stage III or IV.

The consequences are devastating. A 2025 paper in the *Indian Journal of Cancer* reports that while early-stage



"Cancer symptoms are usually subtle: a small painless lump in the breast or rectal bleeding that resembles piles. Patients often ignore them, assuming they'll get resolved on their own"

DR ANIL HEROOR, *Director, Oncological Sciences, KIMS Hospitals, Thane*